

Creature Comfort

It's a royal retreat for the homeless, the destitute and the injured. But you have to be an animal in distress to get in.



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THE PRINCESS AT
HER ANIMAL CLINIC

By Uday Mahurkar

As a child she often saw partridges shot by her father being cooked in the kitchen. She was also an avid listener of stories about how her father shot 32 panthers before the ban on killing wild animals came into force. There was nothing uncommon about it all since hunting was part and parcel of the regal life. But today, Hemangini Kumari Parmar, 34, the princess of Sudasna, a small princely state near Taranga hills in north Gujarat, is following in environment activist and BJP MP Maneka Gandhi's footsteps with her love for animals. Not only has she turned her parents, Maharana Kirtikumarsinhji and mother Laxmi Kumari, into diehard animal protectors but she also runs one of the largest animal care centres in the country.

The Ashirwad Charitable Trust, which gets support from the animal-loving Jain community, has a staggering 1,100 animals—from peacocks and injured monkeys to wild boars—in its care. Spread across a 10-acre family plot on the outskirts of Sudasna, the farm was initially funded by Parmar and her mother who col-

lected around Rs 4 lakh by selling their paintings in Udaipur, Jaipur and other cities. Now the unique animal shelter is home to blue bulls, langurs, geese, donkeys and rabbits, besides dogs, donkeys, horses and cows. The latest entrant is a baby monkey which was orphaned after a dog killed its mother. The Trust has built such a reputation for itself that even the Forest Department brings distressed animals here.

Parmar's journey into the world of animal protection began in Udaipur as a teenager when she saw feeble horses drawing loaded tongas. She was moved by one of the episodes from Maneka Gandhi's programme *Heads and Tails* that aired on television in the mid-1990s, after which she became a vegetarian. Then she treated a cow that had maggots in its hooves, transporting it from Udaipur to her Sudasna haveli. She also nursed an old pony that had been abandoned by its owner. It was then that she started collecting injured animals. Ten years and 1,100 animals later, Parmar is set to recreate the 21st-century version of Noah's Ark on Indian soil. ■